

EDIA CONNOLE

WHAT IS BLACK METAL THEORY? *acatena/acatenae/aconcatenation*¹



Chained book. John Sintram, collection of moralized exempla,
Germany, fifteenth century. 22.3 x 15cm. BL, Add. Ms. 44055.

¹ 'I begin with a catena, really an *acatena* – a broken scriptureless exegetical chain – as the only conceivable way of opening discourse on anti-cosmic black metal, an art that proceeds in principle against the universe as the principle of order, which is what cosmos means, and thus against the very possibility or ground of discourse' (Nicola Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis: Black Mahapralaya,' in *Hideous Gnosis*, ed. by Masciandaro [New York: n.p., 2010], pp. 67-92; p. 73).

Not black metal. Not theory. Not not black metal. Not not theory. Black metal theory. Theoretical blackening of metal. Metallic blackening of theory. Mutual blackening. *Nigredo in the intoxicological crucible of symposia.*

– Nicola Masciandaro²

Already, with the notion of a symposium there is the expectation that music and speech will conjoin and, moreover, conjoin ‘with drinking’ (sum-posion). Most famously of all, Plato’s *Symposium* records a somewhat drunken dialogue on love and beauty from the fourth century BC. Given the misanthropy that characterizes Black metal, we might suppose that the Black Metal Theory Symposium will be more concerned with hatred, but one does not come without the other [...] It is indeed a question of love and hatred and precisely not of judgement, for there is no possibility of conjunction between Black metal and [theory] in any other way.

– Scott Wilson³

Black metal theory [...] presupposes the philial, the epidemic, the strategic tryst.

– Michael O’Rourke⁴

[... and] opposes the perverted secret identity between fan and philosopher in contemporary culture, namely, the situation according to which the fan is an unconscious or sleeping philosopher and the philosopher a mere fan [of the music].

– Nicola Masciandaro⁵

Black metal theory expresses a need to reopen music to the philosophy of music and philosophy to the music of philosophy, in a black way. If philosophy is thought, practicing the love of wisdom (philo-sophia), black metal theory is thought practicing the love of black metal.

– Nicola Masciandaro⁶

2 Nicola Masciandaro, as cited on the inaugural *Black Metal Theory* blog <<http://blackmetalththeory.blogspot.ie/>> (accessed 20/01/12).

3 Scott Wilson, ‘BASileus philosoPHOrum METaloricum’, in *Hideous Gnosis*, pp. 33–51; p. 34.

4 Michael O’Rourke, ‘The Mutual Pesterling of Black Metal and Theory’, in *P.E.S.T.*, ed. by Michael O’Rourke and Karin Sellberg (forthcoming).

5 Nicola Masciandaro, ‘Interview (Dominik Irtenkauf, *Avant-Garde Metal* 2011)’, in this volume.

6 *Ibid.*

The love of black metal is an inside-out mysticism, not only in the sense of a profanation of mysticism, but in the deeper sense of a mystical inversion of mysticism, an unconscious occult recording or perverse intuitive preservation of the heterodox love of God [...] black metal truths remain backwardsly legible within medieval mystical discourse, above all in places where the ordered and integrative movement of the return to the One is reversely accented toward individual reality.

– Nicola Masciandaro⁷

As below, so above.

– Nicola Masciandaro⁸

I pick up the guitar play until I've found a riff that makes me either shudder in fear, cry with pain, tremble with anger and I will play that riff many times over [...] I am never content or never will be with the restrictions set upon me. I will destroy cosmos and return to freedom!

– Donn of Teutoburg Forest⁹

This is the essential reality of black metal as mysticism, its being a musical materialization of the mystical relation in which the transcendent subject and object, self and God, are equally dislocated and secreted in an immanent and blackened inter-becoming of metal with everything, an amorous pestilential alchemy that nigredically melts being into an ancient cosmic essence that cannot be, taking flight through clouds of chaos where stars die, into the darkest divine body, named by Eruigena as 'that which neither creates nor is created [...] [which] is classed among the impossibles, for its essence lies in not being able to be [*cuius differentia est non posse esse*]'.

– Nicola Masciandaro¹⁰

[Black metal theory] is an irruption of thought, an irregular expansion taking inspiration from Black metal, but also from medieval philosophy, [from] extreme noise to extreme silence. Some of it has

7 Nicola Masciandaro 'On the Mystical Love of Black Metal', in this volume.

8 Nicola Masciandaro, 'Reflections from the Intoxological Crucible', in *Black Metal: Beyond The Darkness*, ed. by Tom Howells (London: Black Dog Publishing, 2012), pp. 72–5; p. 75.

9 'Interview with Teutoburg Forest', cited by Nicola Masciandaro in 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 70.

10 Nicola Masciandaro, 'Mystical Love of Black Metal'.

nothing to do with Black metal at all.

– Niall Scott¹¹

[Indeed] if black metal theory is to be worthy of the name then it ought, must even, be a theory of everything.

– Michael O'Rourke¹²

[...] neither for anyone nor for no one [...] the *act* of penetrating once again into the essence of black metal.

– Nicola Masciandaro¹³

[Here] black metal theory is *forged* through the process of its 'tools' being placed in the icy furnace of blackened affinities and affections, giving itself over to the power of modification to which black metal is itself an effect, heterogenous no doubt, but one that opens onto the same Night [...] of *non-knowledge*.

– Scott Wilson¹⁴

The experience of black metal theory [...] is [then] a kind of mutual intoxicating meltdown of thinking about metal and the thought which metal itself is.

– Nicola Masciandaro¹⁵

[It] is the intellectual, imaginative, and physical endurance or undergoing of a topological experiment in which theory and metal are placed inside each other within a space of blackness.

– Nicola Masciandaro¹⁶

Theory and metal find each other in black. Why? Because 'a phenomenal blackness entirely fills the essence of man'.

– Nicola Masciandaro¹⁷

You have become the cancer

¹¹ Niall Scott, *Metal Hammer* (June, 2012), p. 148.

¹² Michael O'Rourke, 'What Does Black Metal Theory Affirm?' <www.academia.edu/3387107/What_Does_Black_Metal_Theory_Affirm> (accessed 21/10/2012).

¹³ Masciandaro, 'Interview (Dominik Irtenkauf, *Avant-Garde Metal* 2011)'.

¹⁴ Wilson, 'BASileus philosoPHOrum METaloricum', p. 45.

¹⁵ Masciandaro, 'Intoxological Crucible', p. 72.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*

¹⁷ *Ibid.*

YOU are the dis-ease ...
 Pitch black death is all that is left ...
 FILL THE VOID WITH BLACK!
 – Blood of the Black Owl¹⁸

The darkness in the music does not have to consume the listener,
 but it is dark – *bleak*, angry, violent.
 – Andrew White¹⁹

[...] an inchoate experience that nevertheless provides the ground-
 less ground of self-reflection in a speculation that reflects, intermi-
 nably, on the im-possibility of indefinite and limitless being.
 – Scott Wilson²⁰

Bleakness manifests most often when [...] faced with what is dis-
 tinctly impersonal: with cloudscares and dimmed, wet treescares.
 Or better yet, anytime [one] witness[es] a stark disfigurement of the
 real by our species. And flowering from this is a bleak outlook cor-
 related with the immense, consistent, and mostly hidden, suffering
 that is our history – our *being*.

– Paul J. Ennis²¹

Humanity as a pestilence upon the earth is clearly standard
 black metal fare. Cancer, in its obsessive struggle to live, turns into
 its own negation. Disease becomes the purity of pitch black death.
 However, it is in the reverberating void of this death that a curious
 affirmation is born, formed from the very stuff of negativity but
 no longer defined by and as death. To paradoxically ‘fill the void
 with black’ is to affirm differently, perversely creating a new mode
 of subjectivity that disregards teleological and providential striv-

18 Blood of the Black Owl, ‘Void’, *A Feral Spirit* (Bindrune Recordings, 2008),
 cited in Steven Shakespeare, ‘Of Plications: A Short Summa On The Na-
 ture Of Cascadian Black Metal’, *Glossator 6: Black Metal*, ed. by Nicola
 Masciandro and Reza Negarestani (New York: Punctum, 2012), p. 21.

19 Andrew White, ‘Letter from Andrew White’, in *Hideous Gnosis*, pp. 277–
 80; p. 280; italicization mine.

20 Wilson, ‘BASileus philosoPHOrum METaloricum’, p. 45.

21 Paul J. Ennis, ‘Bleak Theory’, in *P.E.S.T.*, (forthcoming). Cf. Paul J. Ennis,
 ‘Bleak’, in *A Spell to Ward Off the Darkness*, directed by Ben Rivers and Ben
 Russell (2013; London, UK: Soda Pictures, 2014), DVD, as treated in Edia
 Connole, ‘The Missing Subject of Accelerationism: Heavy Metal’s Wyrd
 Realism’, in this volume.

ing away from death: a sovereign indifference to the machine that generates the boundary between human/inhuman, pure/diseased, living/dead. In Fauna's words:

Under a ragged cloth of sky
And the moon's blazing eye –
Burrow deep in blackest earth
And break further.
– Steven Shakespeare²²

The listener realizes the music as a force rising within their own being, a being that demands expression through ritual destruction of one's own head, the auto-decapitation or self-martyrdom of the self seeking simultaneous release from and deeper entry into the world.

– Nicola Masciandaro²³

'Head' here should be taken in its full range, for the acephalic is a fantasy both of the leaderless (the 'body' of the people rules alone, brought about by that revolutionary act of beheading the sovereign, materially or in principle) and the irrational (headless, the body rules in its singularity and decides on the basis of the affective, and phenomenal, taking on unreason as its shared principle). As such, the acephalic condition of black metal must surpass itself and extend this to a total condition [...] In other words, you can't afford to throw away the head. It must be picked up, made open use of. Not to resuture a lost order to the mediated despair of the present, not to stitch the head back on. Rather, to make its absence and dislocation visible, to make something better of the inherited atrocity [...] To strike a totality by becoming a negative totality together, [...] To take on the abortive passage of the apocalyptic as mandate and injunction, not to do right, but to do wrongly to a wrong world. Never to fall into sadness or dejection at the prospect, but to rage with joy [...] And above all to do this together. To become totally singular and negatively universal is to take on the acephalic mess that we are – by becoming cephaloric, by not just severing but picking up the pieces – and to undo the idiocy of any nostalgia for a purer time. Only from there do we forge Luciferian [...] collectivity: knowing very well that we can't take the thrown, and

²² Shakespeare, 'Of Plications', p. 21; Fauna, *Rain* (2006).

²³ Nicola Masciandaro, 'Black Sabbath's "Black Sabbath": A Gloss on Heavy Metal's Originary Song', *Reconstruction* 9.2 (2009) <<http://reconstruction.eserver.org/092/masciandaro.shtml>> (accessed 13/04/2013).

doing it all the same. Such is the decisive core of black metal refusal, for better or for worse. There's a reason that it isn't *Wolf in the Throne Room*. It's *Wolves*, that strident, impure, unwanted pack of inhuman negativity, the absent crown shattered into knives for and against all.

– Evan Calder Williams²⁴

[In this fashion, black metal theory] treats black metal as a mythology rather than a canon: respectful of its origins, but open to its unpredictable, vermicular development.

– Niall Scott²⁵

It is [ergo] more about speculative interpretations of a musical sub-culture than developing a coherent system on black metal music [itself].

– Niall Scott²⁶

And yet there is a coherence to black metal music. There is a principle according to which we could rightly insist and argue that things are or are not black metal. In this respect black metal theory territorializes the potentiality of a non-systematizable coherence – that its *topos* or place is the black spaces or unreachable interiors/exteriors that systems per se cannot reach.

Because these spaces are heterogenous with respect to different coherent or axiomatic systems, so black metal is not something universally fixed, but a virtually mobile unreachable thing: an unmineable mineral that weirdly relocates its inaccessibility according to the equipment on the surface [whether that be art, design, music, maths, literature, science, philosophy, theology etcetera].

– Nicola Masciandaro²⁷

This is the very condition and principle of black metal theory's politics [...] its final non-determinability and unrealizability, its bursting open. Not not black metal, not not theory, yes yes black metal, yes yes theory.

– Michael O'Rourke²⁸

24 Evan Calder Williams, 'The Headless Horsemen of the Apocalypse', in *Hideous Gnosis*, pp. 137–42.

25 Scott, *Metal Hammer*, p. 148.

26 *Ibid.*

27 Masciandaro, 'Interview (Dominik Irtenkauf, *Avant-Garde Metal* 2011)'.

28 O'Rourke, 'The Mutual Pestering' (forthcoming).

Instead of the power of prohibition and censorship black metal theory serves to increase and expand more and more on that which has been forbidden.

– Niall Scott²⁹

[It is] a site for the real mutation or migration of black metal into other media, into forms that participate in and are not only about black metal. Right now it seems that black metal can withstand the addition of any adjective placed before it (*this* black metal, *that* black metal), where the difference is registered as one of variety within the genre. Black metal theory engages this process from the *other* side.

– Nicola Masciandaro³⁰

Black metal and academic discourse are no doubt heterogenous and cannot be conjoined, but in bringing one into proximity with the other it is essential that this clash should result less in the academic illumination of black metal than in the blackening of discourse itself wherein the forces of black metal restore some of the powers and dangers of discourse which the procedures of academic institutions seek to ward off and master by controlling and delimiting them.

– Scott Wilson³¹

It 'works' as follows [...]

– Paul J. Ennis³²

Nothing comes to mind.

– Nicola Masciandaro³³

This is what we are looking for: black metal theory fucks up academic discourse. SHOCK!

– Scott Wilson³⁴

29 Niall Scott, 'Black Confessions And Absu-Lution', in *Hideous Gnosis*, pp. 221–31; p. 224.

30 Masciandaro, 'Interview (Dominik Irtenkauf, *Avant-Garde Metal* 2011)'.

31 Wilson, 'BASileus philosoPHORum METaloricum', p. 35.

32 Ennis, 'Bleak Theory', see concluding paragraph and footnote regarding Masciandaro.

33 Masciandaro, 'Interview (Dominik Irtenkauf, *Avant-Garde Metal* 2011)'.

34 Scott Wilson, 'Pop Journalism and the Passion for Ignorance', in *Hideous Gnosis*, pp. 247–50; p. 250.

acatena/acatenae/aconcatenation

I begin, opening (/wounding/ openly wounding) discourse on Black metal theory with a catena (pl. catenae), literally a 'chain', from Greek δέω, meaning 'to bind', a medieval form of exegetical commentary composed entirely of a concatenation or 'linking together' of singular responses. Traditionally (and to some extent here), this consisted of a series of extracts or quotes from the (Black metal) Church Fathers, the *Catena Patrum* (*metallum nigri*) or 'chain of the (Black metal) Fathers'. These extracts were arranged, with trivial authorial additions, to elucidate portions of Scripture (/Black metal theory) concerned. Representing what Masciandaro terms 'textual significance as a plenitude spanning the voices of multiple authors',³⁵ this textual form is exemplified by St. Thomas Aquinas' *Catena Aurea*, a thirteenth-century commentary on the four gospels, so contrived that it consists wholly of extracts from other writers, dexterously dovetailed together to form a 'Glossa Continuum' on Scripture. In some cases (as in Masciandaro's own 'Anti Cosmosis: Black Mahapralaya'), a catena (really an *acatena* – where the *a* marks the intimate exteriority of Scripture, and of theory to Black metal music) will form (conceptually, at least) the major or central part of the text, in other cases, the catena (/acatena) occupies the minor or peripheral part of the text, occupying the top and side or only the side margin. It has been proposed that, depending on the way and purpose for which they are chained together, catenae (/acatenae) can be divided into five different types of classifications, ranging from the authenticating to the parabolic (see, for example, Steven Shakespeare's 'The Light that Illuminates Itself, the Dark that Soils Itself: Blackened Notes from Schelling's Underground' and 'Of Plications: A Short Summa On The Nature Of Cascadian Black Metal').³⁶ In all of these

³⁵ Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 70.

³⁶ Philip LeRoy Culbertson, *A Word Fitly Spoken: Content, Transmission, and Adaption of the Parables of Jesus* (New York: SUNY, 1995). Cf. Beryl Smalley, 'The Bible in the Medieval Schools', in *The Cambridge History of the Bible*, vol. 2: *The West from the Fathers to the Reformation*, ed. by G. W. H. Lampe (Cambridge, 1969), pp. 197–220; Shakespeare, 'The Light that Illuminates Itself, the Dark that Soils Itself: Blackened Notes from Schelling's Under-

cases or classifications, however, catenae (/acatenae) are linked together with only such minor adjustment of words as to allow the whole (catena/acatena) to form a continuous commentary. The composer of catenic (/acatenic) form is, then, as Timothy W. Seid suggests, more of an editor or compiler than an author, with very little to add to the work (on this point see the Codex Zacynthius, or Niall Scott's 'Black Confessions and Absu-Lution': '[Black metal/theory] is to repeat words to repeat words: *glos-san homologuein*'.³⁷ A truth that stretches from the genre's sonic inception in second wave 'necro' or 'corpse' sound, sonorously generated through the worst possible equipment to create a dissonant facsimile of the original, to its aesthetic inception in the photocopy, the degraded duplicate that adorns Darkthrone's *Transylvanian Hunger* [Peaceville, 1994]; as Masciandaro notes: 'For Black metal repetition Is the original').³⁸

In light of Alastair Minnis' *Medieval Theory of Authorship* (1984), however, Seid's (/Masciandaro's) remark must be understood in the context of what Graham D. Caie conceives more generally as a resistance to the assertion of authorship in the Middle Ages.³⁹ As Caie notes in "I Do Not Wish To Be Called Auctour, But The Pore Compilatour" [...], the 'absolute' or 'primary efficient cause' was God,

ground', in *Hideous Gnosis*, pp. 5–31; Shakespeare, 'Of Plications', pp. 1–45.

37 Timothy W. Seid, 'Origins of Catena in Gaza' <<http://legacy.earlham.edu/~seidti/iam/catena.html>> (accessed 21/10/12). Scott, 'Black Confessions and Absu-Lution', p. 223.

38 Masciandaro, 'Interview (Dominik Irtenkauf, *Avant-Garde Metal* 2011)'. Cf. Varg Vikernes on Black metal's 'corpse' or 'necro' sound in *Until The Light Takes Us*, directed by Aaron Aites and Audrey Ewell (New York: Factory, 2012) DVD; band member Gyle 'Fenriz' Nagell comments on this Darkthrone album: 'The photo was taken in 1991 in an abandoned house, in the forest not far from the house I grew up in, but by the time we got round to using it in 1994, the photo was nowhere to be found. I had photocopied [it] to give out to magazines worldwide, but I couldn't find the negative, nor the photo itself, so, devil may care as we were in those days, I just sen[t] a photocopy and said, THIS WILL BE THE COVER. Hence the iconic look', as cited in *The Art of Metal*, ed. by Martin Popoff and Malcome Dome (London and New York: Omnibus Press, 2013), p. 147.

39 Alastair Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship: Scholastic Literary Attitudes in the Later Middle Ages* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2010), pp. 73–117; Graham D. Caie, "I Do Not Wish To Be Called Auctour, But The Pore Compilatour": The Plight Of The Medieval Vernacular Poet', in *Miscelanea: A Journal of English and American Studies*, 29 (2004), pp. 9–21.

the *auctor*, 'author', and *auctoritas*, 'authority', one with the cognate term *authenticus*, 'authenticity'.⁴⁰ This belief is borne out in the very logic of the catena (/acatena), itself an ocular analog 'for the cosmic spectacle that held sway during the thousand or so years when catenae were written, namely, the vision of the universe as constituting a great chain of being',⁴¹ a concept which marries Plato's idea of the Good (/God), bound by its own principle of plenitude to generate every possible idea and temporal being (ergo Plotinus, 'It is precisely because there is nothing within the One that all things are from it'),⁴² to Aristotle's *Scala Naturae* or 'Ladder of Nature', where God (/the Good) is conceived as the Prime Mover affecting the world through a series of links, each constituting an individual genus or species of being distinguished by a greater or lesser share in reason and spirit. As Masciandaro explains through Macrobius, pointing to what he calls the latter's 'properly consequential syntax (re. "dregs")',

since Mind emanates from the Supreme God, and Soul from Mind, and Mind, indeed, forms and suffuses all below with life, and since this is the one splendor lighting up everything and visible in all, like a countenance reflected in many mirrors arranged in a row, and since all follow on in continuous succession, degenerating step by step [*degenerantia per ordinem*] in their downward course, the close observer will find that from the supreme God even to the bottom-most dregs of the universe [*a summa deo usque ad ultimam rerum faecem*] there is one tie [*conexio*], binding at every link and never broken. This is the golden chain [*catena aurea*] of Homer which, he tells us, God ordered to hang down from the sky to the earth.⁴³

40 Caie, 'The Medieval Vernacular Poet', p. 10.

41 Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 71.

42 Plotinus, *Enneads*, trans. by Stephen MacKenna (Burdett, NY: Larson, 1992), V.2.1.1., cited in Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 76.

43 Macrobius, *Commentary on the Dream of Scipio*, trans. by William Harris Stahl (New York: Columbia University Press, 1952), pp. 14–15, cited in Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 71.



Deathspell Omega, *Fas – Ite, Maledicti, in Ignem Aeternum*
(Norma Evangelium Diaboli, 2005).

Mathew 25:41; 'Go, Accursed, into Everlasting Fire'.

Supporting the much celebrated aphorism of hermetic philosophy, 'as above, so below', the *catena aurea* situates man in a universe authored by God in which the structure of the microcosm reflects that of the macrocosm through a series of links or succession of secondary causes. (Consequently, as Masciandaro – who exactly reverses this formula – will note: '[a]s the first link and primal mirror produced in this ecstatic [cosmic (a)catenic] emanation, Satan, second only to God, becomes archival, alone, on the basis of being arch-other, the original subject of the most intimate and intolerable intersection between the absolute fact of God and something's being other than God'.)⁴⁴ As Minnis makes plain, this fact was evident in the most characteristic and representative Scriptural exegesis of the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries.⁴⁵ Here, the respective roles of God and man (/ Satan: God 'inverted in the voice of an *ego*'⁴⁶ [(where) inversion (is)

44 Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 76. As envisioned on the cover of Deathspell Omega's *Fas – Ite, Maledicti, in Ignem Aeternum* (pictured above).

45 Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, pp. 73–117.

46 Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 77.

recognized as a universal logical operator for transpositionally revealing-by-concealing and concealing-by-revealing the essence of something [...] inversion repeats without repetition, without recording, keeping the old as the shadow of the new',⁴⁷ ergo Marguerite Porete,

- 47 Masciandaro, 'Mystical Love of Black Metal'. See also Nicola Masciandaro's commentary on Eugene Thacker, 'Day of Wrath', in *Glossator*, pp. 113–15: '*Already an inversion*: Inversion of the divine is identically internal to Christianity and Black metal [...] The inverted cross of Black metal is not a reversal of the upright Christian cross, but a *profanation* of the Petrine cross that reestablishes confusion between human and divine' (p. 113). Cf. Giorgio Agamben, *Profanations*, trans. by Jeff Fort (New York: Zone Books, 2007): 'The term *religio* does not derive, as an insipid and incorrect etymology would have it, from *religare* (that which binds and unites the human and the divine). It comes instead from *relegere*, which indicates the stance of scrupulousness and attention that must be adopted in relations with the gods, the uneasy hesitation (the "re-reading [*rileggere*]") before forms – and formulae – that must be observed in order to respect the separation between the sacred and the profane. *Religio* is not what unites men and gods but what ensures they remain distinct. It is not disbelief and indifference toward the divine, therefore, that stand in opposition to religion, but "negligence," that is, a behaviour that is free and distracted (that is to say, released from the *religio* of norms) before things and their use, before forms of separation and their meaning. To profane means to open the possibility of a special form of negligence, which ignores separation or, rather puts it to a particular use' (p. 75). Hence, the first amongst seven black metal truths that remain backwards legible within medieval mysticism: '1) Irreligion. The principle that divine truth lies beyond religion, an institution that separates rather than unites world and God. "[T]his soul is above the law, | Not contrary to the law," says Porete, in the voice of the Holy Church [*Mirror of Simple Souls*, p. 196]. As opposed to such persons she calls "donkeys, [who] seek God in creatures, in monasteries for prayer, in a created paradise, in words of men and the Scriptures" [*Mirror of Simple Souls*, p. 144]' (Masciandaro, 'Mystical Love of Black Metal'). Agamben aligns this special form of negligence, or that which amounts to irreligion, with play. As he goes on to say: 'The passage from the sacred to the profane can, in fact, also come about by means of an entirely inappropriate use (or, rather, reuse) of the sacred: namely, play. It is well known that the spheres of play and the sacred are closely connected. Most of the games with which we are familiar derive from ancient sacred ceremonies, from divinatory practices and rituals that once belonged, broadly speaking, to the religious sphere. [...] In analyzing the relationship between games and rites, Emile Benveniste shows that play not only derives from the sphere of the sacred but also in some way represents its overturning. The power of the sacred act, he writes, lies in the conjunction of the myth that tells the story and the rite that reproduces and stages it. Play breaks up this unity: as *ludas*, or physical play, it drops the myth and preserves the rite; as *iocus*, or wordplay, it effaces the rite and allows the myth to survive [...] This means

'this soul in herself knows only one thing, that is, the root of all evil, and the abundance of all sins without number, without weight, and without measure'),⁴⁸ in producing Holy Scripture, were described precisely, due to new conceptions of authorial role and literary form adopted and developed in prologues based on Aristotelian theories of causality (as Masciandaro mentions, '[the] impulse, materialized in the initial scream of Teutoburg Forest's *Anti-Subhuman Scum*, "Seeing God's Creation, and Despising it," is explicable as absolute refusal of [this] originary causality that the chain of being manifests, and more precisely, as hatred of the essential weakness or impotence of the absolute one who cannot not make others, the no-thing [*Ein Sof*] perfectly incapable of not creating many things').⁴⁹

The technical philosophical details of these theories (what Masciandaro, in his commentary on Shakespeare's 'Of Plications', would term '*God's theory*: The theory whose image is life itself',⁵⁰

that play frees and distracts humanity from the sphere of the sacred, without simply abolishing it. The use to which the sacred is returned is a special one that does not coincide with utilitarian consumption' (pp. 75–6). Hence, the playful, purposefully obfuscating methodology employed herein: BLACK METAL THEORY IS 'LUDIC' (Nicola Masciandaro, cited in Ben Ratliff, 'Thank You, Professor, That Was Putrid', in *The New York Times* [December 14, 2009] <http://www.nytimes.com/2009/12/15/arts/music/15metal.html?pagewanted=all&_r=0> [accessed 21/12/12], my emphasis). Cf. Nicola Masciandaro and Reza Negarestani, 'Black Metal Commentary', in *Hideous Gnosis*: 'Haunted by the principle of *ignotum per ignotius* as its own logical spectre, the clarifying-by-complicating and explicating-by-obfuscating movement of commentary, which is captured in Montaigne's complaint that "everything swarms [fourmille] with commentaries," is analogous to Black metal as a motion/anti-motion of artistic expression that articulates from and through enclosure, or, as Dante knew, bubbles to the surface from black depths: "Fixed in the slime they say: 'We were sullen in the sweet air gladdened by the sun, bearing within us the sluggish fumes [*accidioso fummo*]; now we are sullen in the black mire'. This hymn they gurgle in their throats [*si gorgoglian*] ne la strozza, for they cannot speak it in full words" (*Inferno* 7.121–6)' (pp. 257–66; p. 261, my emphasis).

48 Marguerite Porete, *The Mirror of Simple Souls*, trans. by Ellen L. Babinsky (New York: Paulist Press, 1993), pp. 88–9, cited in Masciandaro, 'Mystical Love of Black Metal'.

49 Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', pp. 74–7.

50 '[...] as indiscrete animation of the Real. Cf. "Every life is some form of thought [...] while men may recognize grades in life they reject grades in thought; to them there are thoughts (full and perfect) and anything else is no thought. This is simply because they do not seek to establish

cf. 'Anti Cosmosis: Black Mahapralaya', in which 'Chaos [is] the ultimate expression of the most horrible heresy: the fact that anything is happening at all',⁵¹ ergo Black metal artist Shamaatae of Arckanum's cosmos-collapsing self-definition: 'I am a living and a revolving cosmos of Kaos. I can't stay as one and in one way',⁵² or Donn of Teutoburg Forest's invocation: 'I will destroy cosmos and return to freedom!' As Masciandaro makes plain: 'The chain principle is an ontological wholism. It threads the fact of universe itself [...] The cosmic catena is the necessary point of identity, piercing every entity, between essence and existence, the invisible thing making it so that everything is next to something else and part of everything itself. It is thus in a full and total sense the chain of being, the fact of being's being a chain or binding'.⁵³

Hence, Masciandaro's own 'cosmic dissolution', what he terms 'Black Mahapralaya', which begins in Black metal, in Black metal's 'eternal quest for an infernal tone [Dagon]'⁵⁴ that, contra the ear-pleasing sound of the celestial spheres so contrived as to inspire order in the sub-lunary realm, tends toward infinite chaos and cosmic exteriority, and ends with Mahapralaya: 'the real termination of the evolutionary process [...] the final annihilation of the world, when the world becomes what it was in the beginning, namely *nothing* [Meher Baba, *Discourses*]'.⁵⁵ 'The anti-cosmic structure of

what Life is ... Contemplation (theoria) and its object constitute a living thing, a Life, two inextricably one" (Plotinus, *The Enneads*, trans. Stephen MacKenna [Burdett, NY: 1992], 3.8.8). Cusa's understanding of the human as living image of infinite art "marks a crucial link between medieval mysticism and modern conceptions of human creativity" (Thomas A. Carlson, *The Indiscrete Image: Infinitude and Creation of the Human* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2008], 114). As such Cusa may be an especially useful figure for reopening the question of the ontology of theory in relation to creative evolution, for reinventing theory as art of becoming, and more specifically, for the development of Black Metal Theory as contemplative practice of Black Metal' (Masciandaro, commentary on Shakespeare, 'Of Plications', p. 36).

51 Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 74.

52 Shamaatae of Arckanum, cited in *ibid.*, p. 82.

53 *Ibid.*, pp. 71–2. Cf. Connole, 'Heavy Metal's Wyrd Realism', in this volume.

54 Inquisition, *Ominous Doctrines of the Perpetual Mystical Macrocosm* (Hells Headbangers Records, 2011), sleeve.

55 Meher Baba, 'The Beginning and the End of Creation', *Discourses*, 6th ed., 3 vols. (San Francisco: Sufism Reoriented, 1973), I, p. 46.

such metallic factual blackening of experience, which makes the whole moment of life immediately fulfill Quentin Meillassoux's definition of facticity as the narrow passage through which thought is able to exit itself [and] we are able to make our way toward the absolute [*After Finitude* (2008)]',⁵⁶ is perfectly explicit, not only and less, in terms of Black metal shaman Shamataae's cosmos-collapsing self-definitions viz. '[...] I am my own influence',⁵⁷ but in terms of Masciandaro's own Master Meher Baba's analysis of the structure of individuality and its development through the course of evolution, reincarnation and involution in *The Divine Theme*. Cf. 'God, the Oversoul, alone is real. Nothing exists but God. The different souls are in the Oversoul and one with it. The processes of evolution, reincarnation and realisation are all necessary in order to enable the soul to gain self-consciousness. In the process of winding, *sanskaras* become instrumental for the evolution of consciousness though they also give *sanskaric* bindings; and in the process of unwinding, *sanskaric* attachments are annihilated, though the consciousness which has been gained is fully retained [...] "A" soul becomes "Z" soul after going through evolution, reincarnation and the process of realisation. It is only in the God-state that consciousness is free'⁵⁸ Or, as we read elsewhere: 'The process of perception runs parallel to the process of creation, and the reversing of the process of perception without obliterating consciousness amounts to realising the nothingness of the universe as a separate entity [Meher Baba, *Discourses*]',⁵⁹

56 Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', pp. 80–2; Quentin Meillassoux, *After Finitude: An Essay on the Necessity of Contingency*, trans. by Ray Brassier (London: Continuum, 2008), p. 63. Cf. 'Not *how* the world is, is the mystical, but *that* it is' (Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, trans. by D.F. Pears and B.F. McGuinness [London and New York: Routledge, 2014], p. 88: '6.44 It is not *how* things are in the world that is mystical, but *that* it exists', or regarding 'things [that] are in: not in the original, which runs, [Tr. 6.44] Not *how* the world is, is the mystical, but *that* it is' [Max Black, *A Companion to Wittgenstein's "Tractatus"* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1971), p. 375]), as Masciandaro would go on to note, '*Id est*, facticity is God.' ('Anti-Cosmosis', p. 86, note 34).

57 Shamaatae of Arckanum, cited in Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 83.

58 Meher Baba, 'The Divine Theme', in *God Speaks: The Theme of Creation and Its Purpose*, 2nd ed. (Oakland, CA: Sufism Reoriented, 1997), pp. 220–8; p. 220; Chart IX. "A" soul becomes "Z" soul'.

59 Meher Baba, *Discourses*, I, p. 98, cited in various places throughout Masci-

In 'Remembering everything's nothingness today' [Aluk Todolo, 'Occult Rock VIII', *Occult Rock* (Ajna Offensive, 2012)], bergmetal theorist Denys X. Abaris too has recourse to Meher Baba and the concept of Mahapralaya, in his commentary on the trisonic intersections of mountains, mysticism and metal [*Bergmetal: Oro-Emblems of the Musical Beyond* (2014)]. Of Aluk Todolo, a band which takes its name from Indonesian animism, the 'Way of the Ancestors [*Aluk To Dolo*]' followed by the Torajo [literally, 'people of the highlands'], he says that they subject ancestrality itself to ritual abuse, 'transposing the Cold Black Metal of the Occidental Alp into the steamy equatorial volcano of Occult Rock [...] a mountain of metal prediscursivity, the site of a musical mass wherein a metalhead stays without affirming any fidelity of identity, where he may say, "I know where I am if no one asks me." Hence the manner in which the question of metal identity is answered: "Aren't you afraid that people will think you're fuckin' hippies [...] ? [to which Aluk Todolo respond:] Not really no, and we don't care. If someone thinks that well I think the album shall clear everything up. And I see no difference between a hippie and a Black Metal head by the way. They both have long hair and drink booze and smoke pot the same way.'" ⁶⁰ Having acknowledged that 'this answer is at once, indifferentially, both very true and very stupid', ⁶¹ Denys X. Abaris seizes on the issue of the metalhead's long hair, a sign of protest shared with and stemming from the countercultural movement of the 1960s, but more presciently understood as the desired look for maximal effect in windmilling or beat-per-riff head banging. In likening the planet's magnetic field lines which flow from the spherical 'head' of Earth like hair and beard to the innumerable uni-

andaro's oeuvre, most notably in 'Absolute Secrecy: On the Infinity of Individuation', in *Speculation, Heresy, and Gnosis in Contemporary Philosophy of Religion: The Enigmatic Absolute*, ed. by Joshua Ramey and Mathew Harr Faris (forthcoming). Cf. Meher Baba, 'The Removal of Sanskaras: I', in *Discourses*, I, pp. 68-79, re. the Vedantic formula of 'Neti, Neti' or 'no, no' that Masciandaro mapped onto the rubric of black metal theory: 'Not black metal. Not theory. Not not black metal. Not not theory. [...] [thus gaining ground towards the enlightened state of "I am God" (p. 79)]'.

60 Lieut. Nab Saheb of Kashmir and Denys X. Abaris, O.S.L., *Bergmetal: Oro-Emblems of the Musical Beyond* (Austin and New York: HWORDE, 2014), pp. 40-1.

61 Saheb and Abaris, *Bergmetal*, p. 41.

verses that flow out of the mystical head of man, he quotes Meher Baba again: “There are [countless] universes, which are interlaced with one another. One universe creates another in a chain reaction. These universes are so numerous that even Sadgurus cannot count them [...] It is astonishing that though the chains of these universes come out of the Sadguru and then merge back into him, they are still uncountable through his physical eyes [...] These universes come out of the Sadguru and merge back into him after aeons. This is called Mahapralaya [...] Each individual being is a universe unto himself [...] So first try to get hold of the head, because out of it comes everything. [Baba drew a man’s head and hair.] The barber’s work is to shave the head. And who is the barber in this case? Mahapralaya. For when it occurs, all the hairs – universes – on God’s head are shaved off. It is said that the universes pour out of the Godhead. They are like God’s hair. Your head may symbolise God, and your hair the universes” (MB).⁶² Baba’s symbology, which offers the possibility of a teratology – God as severed head with hair; melancholic metalhead weighed down by the dross of the multiverse, until the coming of Mahapralaya, self-styled cephalophore who, taking the head in hand, shaves it – is prefigured by Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, ‘mystical ur-cephalophore’⁶³ of the Middle Ages [cf. ‘Leave Me In Hell’, re. the eponymous *Black Metal* (Success, 1992) album]) derived from generations of commentaries on Aristotle’s *Physica and Metaphysica*.⁶⁴

62 Saheb and Abaris, *Bergmetal*, pp. 44–5; no citation, pagination, or reference to a specific Meher Baba text is given, but cf. ‘Love is weeping’ <<http://www.lordmeher.org/rev/index.jsp?pageBase=page.jsp&nextPage=867>> (accessed 08/03/15).

63 Nicola Masciandaro, ‘Decapitating Cinema,’ *And They Were Two In One And One In Two*, ed. by Nicola Masciandaro and Eugene Thacker (London: Schism, 2014), p. 85.

64 Edia Connole, ‘Leave Me In Hell,’ in this volume. See Masciandaro’s discussion of chirality and evolutionary biosemiotics with respect to the *what/that* structure of the question in Martin Heidegger’s concept of Dasein, in ‘Unknowing Animals,’ *Speculations II*, ed. by Michael Austin, Paul J. Ennis, Fabio Gironi, and Thomas Gokey (New York: Punctum, 2011), pp. 228–44; see also Masciandaro’s discussion of chaos as ‘anticosmic impulse’, but note Masciandaro’s understanding of chaos vis-a-vis inversion and profanation regarding what he terms, in relation to Reza Negarestani, an ‘original whim from beyond [ergo Meher Baba, on “The Whim, or Lahar,” in *God Speaks*, pp. 78–87: “The cause which led the most finite Nothing, latent in the in-

In explaining the *Metaphysica* shortly after 1270, St. Thomas Aquinas' teacher Albert the Great had, for example, distinguished between those who believed there were five kinds of causes and those who believed there were only four ('[1] that from which, as immanent material, a thing comes into being, [...] [2] The form or pattern, i.e. the definition of the essence, the classes which include this, and the parts included in the definition. [3] That from which the change or the resting from change first begins [...] [4] The end, i.e. that for the sake of which a thing is').⁶⁵ Partisans of the four-cause theory were identified by Albert as 'Aristotelians' because, unlike Plato and his followers, who had arrived at a five-fold division of causes by differentiating between an 'efficient cause' of being and a 'moving cause' of generation and change, Aristotle did not posit an 'efficient cause' that was not a 'moving cause' also (ergo the angelic first link in Masciandaro's own *acatenic* emanation delivered at the inaugural Black Metal Theory Symposium, *Hideous Gnosis* [Brooklyn, 2009]: 'God or the good or the place does not take place, but is the taking place [*aver-luogo*] of the entities, their innermost exteriority').⁶⁶ Cf. Aristotle, 'One might sus-

finite Everything, to manifest itself as infinite Nothingness, is the original cause called the 'CAUSE'. This Cause is just nothing but the WHIM or lahar of God. This original whim can also be called the first 'WORD' uttered by God - 'WHO AM I?' (p. 78), namely], '*Incognitum Hactenus*', in 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 74. Cf. Reza Negarestani, *Cyclonopedia: Complicity with Anonymous Materials* (Melbourne: re.press, 2008), p. 49 (the evental analog of which is the spiraling anomaly seen in the predawn Norwegian sky three days before the inaugural Black Metal Theory Symposium, *Hideous Gnosis* [Brooklyn, 2009]; on this point see Masciandaro, 'the Intoxological Crucible', p. 72; image in *Hideous Gnosis*, p. 92). Compare, for example, Quentin Meillassoux, 'The Immanence of the World Beyond', in *The Grandeur of Reason: Religion, Tradition, and Universalism*, ed. by Conor Cunningham and Peter Candler (London: SCM Press, 2010), pp. 444-78, with Baba's concept of Mahapralaya, wherein, as Masciandaro notes, we witness 'the unveiling of a fourth world beyond the triplex domain of this one, which is composed of the nested intersection of gross, subtle, and mental spheres, or in Meillassoux's terms, matter, life, and thought', in 'Silence: A Spell To Ward Off All Darkness', in this volume.

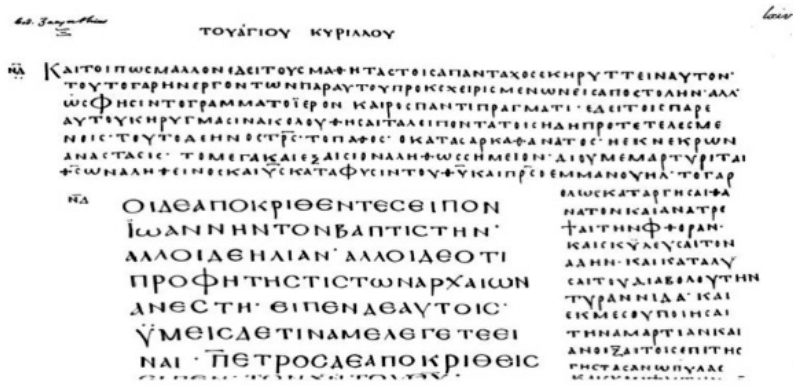
65 Aristotle, *Metaphysica* V. 1. 24-34, in *The Basic Works of Aristotle*, ed. by Richard McKeon (New York: The Modern Library, 2001), p. 752.

66 Giorgio Agamben, *The Coming Community*, trans. by Michael Hardt (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), p. 14, cited in Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 67.

pect that Hesiod was the first to look for such a thing – or someone else who put love or desire among existing things as a principle, as Parmenides, too, does; for he, in constructing the genesis of the universe says: “Love first of all the Gods she planned.” And Hesiod says: “First of all things was chaos made, and then [...] Broad-breasted earth, [...] And love, [a]mid all the gods pre-eminent,” which implies that among existing things there must be from the first a cause which will move things and bring them together’, namely, ‘the first mover [...] itself unmoved’ [*Metaphysica* I. 3. 23-31, IV. 8. 30-32].⁶⁷ In this, as in Masciandaro’s evaluation, ‘the satanic principle is in essence the inversely maximal experience of the most minimal negation performed in the double ecstasy of creation, following Pseudo-Dionysius, who writes that “the very cause of the universe [...] is also carried outside of himself [...] He is [...] enticed away from his transcendent dwelling place and comes to abide within all things, and he does so by virtue of his supernatural and ecstatic capacity to remain, nevertheless, within himself”’ [*DN* 4.13]),⁶⁸ thus we arrive at a four-fold causal theory of things: the efficient and moving cause, the material cause, the formal cause, and the final cause.

67 Aristotle, *The Basic Works*, p. 696 and p. 75, respectively.

68 Masciandaro, ‘Anti-Cosmosis’, pp. 76–7; Pseudo Dionysius, *The Complete Works*, trans. by Colm Luibheid and Paul Rorem (New York: Paulist Press, 1987), *Divine Names*, 4.13 (712B, p. 82).



Facsimile of the Codex Zacynthius with catena,
in which scripture is repeated, sixth–seventh century.

This view won wide acceptance and provided the paradigm for Aristotelian prologues which became popular in arts and theology faculties in the thirteenth century. While the prologues of the *artistaerae* typically began with a discussion of the material cause (namely, '[2] The form or pattern, i.e. the definition of the essence, the classes which include this, and the parts included in the definition'),⁶⁹ their primary interest and aim being in comprehensive definition, subdivision, and analysis of the subject matter therein, they usually ended with a discussion of the efficient cause (namely, '[1] that from which, as immanent material, a thing comes into being')⁷⁰ which received only cursory treatment. For as Minnis does well to relay, '[a]fter the *auctour* of one's textbook had been identified as Priscian, Aristotle or whoever, there seemed to be little more to say'.⁷¹ Correlatively, while the *artistaerae* were overtly concerned with the formal cause of the science in question (namely, '[3] That from which the change or the resting from change first begins')⁷² as it pertained to the proper modes of

69 Aristotle, *Basic Works*, p. 752.

70 *Ibid.*

71 Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 77.

72 *Ibid.*

procedure and correct order of study therein, they paid little or no attention to the formal cause the *auctor*, in writing his book, had brought into being. In contradistinction, the theologians, who were working with divinely-inspired texts, had a special interest in the efficient and formal causes of the books of the Bible, and they tailored their Aristotelian prologues accordingly. From this derived discussions of authorial role and literary form which possess a degree of complexity and sophistication not found in prologues to texts produced by merely human agency.

In one such prologue, to the first commentary on Peter Lombard's *Sentences* to be issued from Oxford (c. 1241–8), the Dominican, Richard Fishacre, differentiated between the diverse instrumental efficient causes of theology, namely, its human *auctores*, and its primary efficient cause, God: 'Although therefore some part of sacred Scripture seems to have been written by Moses, and similarly some part by the prophets, some by the Evangelists, and some by the Apostles, yet not they themselves but God both spoke and wrote by them, as the principal efficient cause by the instrument'.⁷³ While the Aristotelian prologue had already made its appearance in Scriptural exegesis in the commentaries on St. Mark and the Acts of the Apostles produced by Hugh of St. Cher at St. Jacques in Paris during the period 1230–1236, it was first applied in exegesis of the Old Testament by Guerric of St. Quentin, who held the chair of philosophy there between 1233 and 1242. In the commentary of this young exegete, we read:

The efficient cause is twofold, namely moving and operating. The operating cause is Isaiah, which is understood by the supposition of this word, 'he saw'. But there is also a cause which is efficient and not operating, which is noted here: 'by the spirit', namely the Holy Spirit, which moved Isaiah that he should write. The Holy Spirit itself did not write, which is noted in that it says 'by the spirit'.⁷⁴

This concept of a twofold efficient cause (*duplex causa efficiens*) became a popular formula for summary description of the inspired authorship of Biblical texts, whereby God was regarded as

⁷³ As cited in Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 78.

⁷⁴ As cited in *ibid.*, p. 79. Cf. Beryl Smalley, *The Study of the Bible in the Middle Ages* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1964), pp. 388–9.

the principle *auctour* or 'unmoved mover' of such a book, and its human *auctour* as both 'moved' by God and 'moving' in producing the text; a point punctuated in prologues to the Psalter and the Apocalypse mistakenly ascribed to Albert the Great:

From these statements it is clear what are the efficient causes of this book, because the cause which is moving and not moved is the holy Spirit, while the cause which is moving and moved is David himself.

The efficient cause which is moving and not moved was the entire Trinity, revealing to Christ the man [...] The cause moving and moved was the man Christ, and the angel, and John.⁷⁵

Human feelings and emotions also played a part in the *via causalitatis*, and these came under the heading 'causes moving to write' (*causae moventes ad scribendum*). In the prologue to his commentary on Romans, for example, St. Thomas analyzed the emotions of fear and love as possible causal forces. In like fashion, his teacher Albert had, in his commentary on the prologue to Lombard's *Sentences* (written c. 1245-1250), distinguished between the *auctour* and the *causae moventes* (final cause, material cause and formal cause) which moved the author to write; in analyzing the same prologue St. Thomas would provide a similar explanation.⁷⁶ Writing much later, in the fourteenth century, Thomas Waley, an Oxford Dominican, divided the efficient cause, of *De civitate Dei*, into the *causa effectiva librorum*, attributed to St. Augustine, and the *causa movens ad scribendum*, attributed to the Saint's personal reasons for writing. Other texts were taken to have had an even more complex motivation and, in these cases, commentators were not content to speak of a merely double but triple even quadruple efficient causality. St. Bonaventure, for example, in his commentary on St. Luke's Gospel (c. 1254-7), defined a *triplex causa efficiens*: the Holy Spirit, divine grace and the evangelist, and the Paris Dominican, Nicholas Goran, and the Cambridge Dominican, John Russel, both spoke of a *quadruplex causa efficiens* at work in the Apocalypse: God, Christ, the angel who visited St. John on Patmos, and St. John himself.⁷⁷ The element of comparison indicated by these accounts of double,

⁷⁵ As cited in Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 79.

⁷⁶ *Ibid.*, p. 80.

⁷⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 81.

triple and quadruple efficient causality is important because it not only shows the exegetes' belief in the basic unity and affinity of the roles of God and man in producing Holy Scripture, but the attention paid to discriminating between what was perceived therein to be the primary efficient cause and the instrumental efficient causes meant that all involved received due recognition, with important consequences for the development of literary theory.⁷⁸

As applied in literary analysis, Aristotle's four-fold theory of causality may seem to us a feigned framework (cf. 'I am my own cause according to my essence, which is eternal, and not according to my becoming, which is temporal' [Meister Eckhart, Sermon 52].⁷⁹ This 'exuberant sacrilegious signification of divinity in excess of deity', essential to which 'is the principle, contra Aristotle, that negation is not the opposite of assertion, but the assertion of what is beyond it',⁸⁰ is [as Masciandaro maintains], 'the upside down truth on which the Christian ecclesia and black metal *kvl*t are both founded: "I pray to God to make me free of God," says Eckhart',⁸¹ ergo Teutoberg Forest's *Anti-Subhuman Scum*: '[in itself] a statement of absolutizing elitism, a hate-exhausting psychic engine for transhumanation. The human [oneself-as-human] is overcome by including itself in that which it refuses as beneath itself. One hates God's creation to become god – a trajectory spelled out in the album notes: "DO YOUR EYES SEE ALL THAT IS? | ARE WE MERE SLAVES BOUND BY EARTH? | OR GODS?"'⁸² It is in following this trajectory that, as Eckhart would assay, 'man enters into that eternal essence that once he was, that he is now and evermore shall remain'), but from the thirteenth century the *via causalitatis* (conversely) brought medieval exegetes significantly closer to their human *auctores* and was a central force in the re-shaping of literary values of the later Middle Ages.

⁷⁸ *Ibid.*, pp. 81–4, cf. Smalley, *Bible in the Middle Ages*, pp. 281–355.

⁷⁹ Meister Eckhart, Sermon 52, in *The Essential Writings of Christian Mysticism*, ed. by Bernard McGinn (New York: Modern Library, 2006), pp. 438–43; p. 442.

⁸⁰ Masciandaro, 'Mystical Love of Black Metal', in this volume.

⁸¹ *Ibid.*

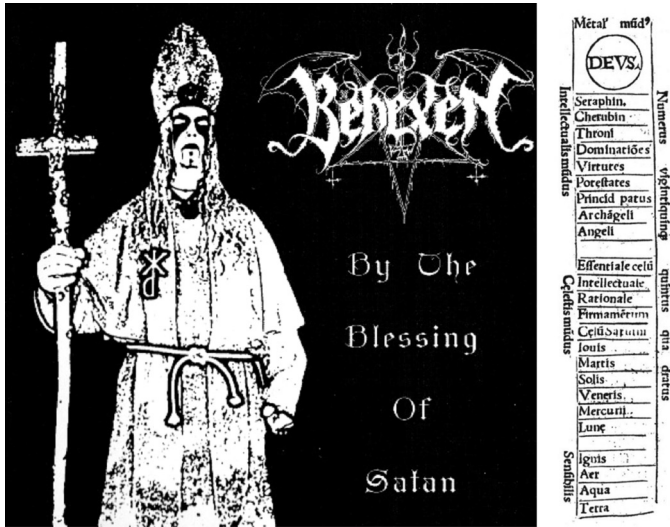
⁸² Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', pp. 75–6, note 16.

At stake here is the centrality of scholasticism and, in particular, the centrality of scholastic scriptural exegesis to the development of (Black metal) theory (i.e. 'the terrifying discontinuous continuities and continuous discontinuities between the reality of what is thought and the image of thought [...] [which] points the way [backwards or forwards?] into the superior, more pleasurable suffering wherein the noble lover, [...] the one who loves thinking about the loved one [Black metal], [...] knows full well the reality of the thought-image he loses himself in and wholly enjoys its actualization of the original dark out of which it and his own being strangely appear [...] Here we see the lovely, speculative hideous gnosis of an essentially citational erotic consciousness, the unnamable entity who, sitting in the medieval chained library of the body, practices loving things in the intellectual mirror of his own most cosmic abyss' [Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis']),⁸³ the decisive event of which, was the shifting of focus, in the Aristotelian prologue, from the divine to the human realm: different levels of authorship were acknowledged – the efficient cause could be double, triple, even quadruple, contingent on the specific causal process, and different motivations were recognized – personal reasons were perceived to play a crucial part, now operating in tandem with the all-important (but seldom overbearing) aspect of divine direction. In short, Aristotle's theory of causality, as interpreted by late medieval scholasticism, 'helped to bring about a new awareness of the integrity of the individual human *auctour*'.⁸⁴ Whereas secular and scriptural exegesis up to the twelfth century, in keeping with the medieval veneration of the past, had really only been interested in an *auctour* insofar as he was an *auctoritas* – someone to be believed and imitated, in the thirteenth century, with the unique scholastic tailoring of the Aristotelian prologue, a new type of exegesis emerged, in which was recognized the moral, didactic, and sty-

83 Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', pp. 86–7; Masciandaro, 'Black Sabbath's "Black Sabbath."' Cf. Masciandaro and Negarestani, 'Black Metal Commentary', in *Hideous Gnosis*, pp. 257–66; Nicola Masciandaro, 'Nicola Masciandaro said' in 'Comments', in *ibid.*, pp. 269–71: '... perpetually exchanging places with Satan, at the mediating position between the possible and impossible' (p. 271).

84 See Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 84; pp. 73–84.

listic strategies one could call his own; in sum, the human *auctores* individual literary activities began to receive more attention.



Behexen, *By The Blessing of Satan* (Woodcut Records, 2004).
Charles de Boulle, depiction of an ascending linear order in nature
(with 'metal' and 'mud' curiously positioned at the summit),
from the *Physicorum Elementorum* (1512).

Eminently aware of the similarities and distinctions that could be drawn between the Bible and secular texts, medieval theologians stressed, on the one hand, the unique status of the Holy Book, and on the other, their belief that young exegetes should be trained in the natural arts before attempting to understand the infinitely more complex (supernatural) sacred page. Such accentuation became, in the twelfth century, a regular trait in the debate regarding the true hierarchy of the branches of knowledge and the proper order in which the different arts and sciences should be studied. As if *literally* climbing Aristotle's 'Ladder of Nature', Hugh of St. Victor held that 'all natural arts are related to divine science in such a way that the inferior science, correctly organized in the hierarchy, leads to the superior', correlatively, the declared purpose of his *Didascalicon* is to prescribe proficiency in the natural arts within a course of study

culminating in the explication of sacred Scripture.⁸⁵ In like manner, Conrad of Hirsau's *Dialogus super auctores* warns that secular texts are not to be studied for their own sake, but as requisite priming for the (climbing to) more difficult texts of Holy Writ.⁸⁶

Traceable back to the Church Fathers, these attitudes and priorities can be found flourishing in the Biblical exegesis of St. Augustine, St. Jerome, and St. Gregory the Great: despite what has been identified as the influence of late-antique schooling and methods of grammatical training on the exegesis of Augustine, he himself professed a preference for substance over expression.⁸⁷ Jerome, who had been taught by Donatus, the famous Roman grammarian and teacher of rhetoric, similarly insisted on the primacy of sense over words, and in a dedicatory letter to his *Moralia in Job* (c. 580–95), Gregory, who had retained (from Jerome) his teacher's concern for content over form, warns the reader not to seek out 'literary noseays', because in interpreters of Holy Writ, he says, 'fruitless verbiage' is repressed.⁸⁸

Gregory, who once quipped that it was 'unbecoming' to think that he should 'tie down the words of the heavenly oracle to the rules of Donatus', altered traditional techniques of textual commentary to meet the demands of divinely inspired Scripture.⁸⁹ Whereas the Roman grammarians had been interested solely in the literal (also called historical) sense of the text, the exegete was obliged

85 As cited in Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 35; *De sacramentis christanae fidei*, prologus, cap.vi (pr. PL, clxxvi, 185C); *Didascalicon*, ed. C. H. Buttner, Catholic University of America, *Studies in Medieval and Renaissance Latin*, x (Washington, 1939), pp. 1–3. Cf. Henri de Lubac, *Medieval Exegesis: The Four Senses of Scripture* 4 vols (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2000), I, pp. 74–94.

86 See Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 35; R. B. C. Huygens, 'Notes sur le *Dialogus super auctores* de Conrad de Hirsau et le commentaire sur Theodule de Bernard d'Utrecht', *Latomus* 13 (1954), pp. 420–8. On the emergence of theology as a discipline and medieval views on its position within the hierarchy of the sciences, see G. R. Evans, *Old Arts and New Theology* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1980).

87 See Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 34; H. S. Marou, *Augustine et la Fin de la Culture Antique* (Paris, 1938), pp. 9–26; pp. 47–83.

88 As cited in Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 34; *Patrologia Latina*, ed. by J. P. Migne (Paris, 1844–64), lxxv, pp. 515–16.

89 As cited in Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 33, no source given. Cf. *Patrologia Latina*, lxxv, pp. 5–16.

to concentrate on the spiritual senses of the books of the Bible. To this end, Gregory offered a three-fold method of exposition – literal, allegorical, and moral (also called tropological) – which, along with John Cassian's four-fold method, remained the dominant model for Biblical interpretation in the Middle Ages.⁹⁰ The four-fold method was summarized and survives in a rhyme attributed to Augustine of Dacia:

*Littera gesta docet, quid credas allegoria,
Moralis quid agas, quo tendas anagogia*⁹¹

[The letter shows us what God and our ancestors did;
The allegory shows us where our faith is hid;
The moral meaning gives us the rule of daily life;
The anagogy shows us where we end our strife.]⁹²

90 I follow Minnis here, but this is a bit of a misleading statement, because even though the four senses of scripture were largely recognized, while Minnis claims that their consolidation occurred in Cassian, and that of the three senses in Gregory, Origen is undoubtedly the well-spring, Augustine too, as he speaks of four senses in chapters 5–6 of *De utilitate credendi*, but he gives them different names than the medievals do. For a much more detailed (though somewhat dated) study than Minnis' own, see Smalley, *Bible in the Middle Ages*, pp. 281–355. For his fine treatment of Origen's influence in relation to setting the four-senses as foundations for the Christian approach to scripture, see Joseph Dyer, 'The Psalms in Monastic Prayer', in *The Place of the Psalms in the Intellectual Culture of the Middle Ages*, ed. Nancy Van Deusen (Albany, NY: State University of New York Press, 1999), pp. 68–72. For a helpful study on the issue of method in relation to the four senses, see de Lubac, *Medieval Exegesis: The Four Senses of Scripture*, II, pp. 207–16. And for a good chronological summary of medieval exegesis, beginning with Gregory the Great, and taking into account the fact that others, such as Andrew of St. Victor in the twelfth century, did not focus entirely, if at all, on the four senses, see Mary A. Mayeski, 'Early Medieval Exegesis: Gregory I to The Twelfth Century', in *A History of Biblical Interpretation, Volume 2: The Medieval through the Reformation Period*, ed. by Alan J. Hauser and Duane F. Watson (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2009), pp. 86–112.

91 As cited in Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 35. Minnis does not provide an English translation, but attributes this distich to Augustine of Dacia through F. Chatillon; see 'Vocabulaire et prosodie du distique attribué à Augustin de Dacie sur les quatre sens de l'écriture', in *L'Homme devant Dieu: Melanges offerts au père Henri de Lubac* (Lyon, Fourvière, 1963–4), ii, pp. 17–28. Cf. Dyer, 'The Psalms in Monastic Prayer', p. 69; Dyer locates it more specifically in the latter's *Rotulus Pugillaris* (1260).

92 Robert M. Grant with David Tracy, *A Short History of Biblical Interpreta-*

The foundations for this approach to Scripture, already fortified in Greek philosophy and rabbinic exegesis, were articulated as early as the third century by the Biblical scholar Origen. Informed by the belief that 'the treasures of Scripture were to be unlocked primarily through the action of the mind upon them', Origen's literary activity exerted a profound influence on the Latin Fathers, who, while balancing the literal meaning of the text against the myriad of extended meanings it could support, generally preferred the latter.⁹³ In explaining Origen's popularity, Jean Leclercq has observed that 'what was sought in him was not so much a doctrine as a mentality and, most of all, a way of interpreting Holy Scripture'.⁹⁴ This is aptly captured in Jerome, who, in praising the speculative flights of his expansive imagination, in the preface to his translation of Origen's homilies on Ezekiel, speaks glowingly of the way in which the author 'surrendered all the sails of his genius to the blowing winds and, departing from the land (or "literal" sense), launched out into the open sea'.⁹⁵ Origen tirelessly sought out the spiritual mean-

tion (New York: Fortress Press, 1984), p. 85. Cf. Henri de Lubac, 'On an Old Distich: The Doctrine of the "Fourfold Sense" in Scripture', in *Theological Fragments* (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 1989), p. 109; de Lubac translates this quite literally as 'the letter teaches us what took place, the allegory what to believe, the moral what to do, the anagogy what goal to strive for'. Ergo Masciandaro's methodology of hyper-literal anagogy: 'Just as anagogy – the proverbial "foretaste of paradise" wherein the sensing of the text transforms into actual participation in the truth – is characterized by an inversion of agency whereby what you thought was pulling you down is really pulling you up [Pseudo-Dionysius, *Divine Names*, in *The Complete Works*, 3.1, 680B–680D, pp. 68–9], hyper-literal anagogy finds the profoundest meaning already and inexplicably present within its tactile, manipulative surface' (Nicola Masciandaro, *Sufficient Unto The Day: Sermones Contra Solitudinem* [London: Schism, 2014], p. 3).

93 As cited in Dyer, 'The Psalms in Monastic Prayer', p. 69.

94 Jean Leclercq, *The Love of Learning and the Desire for God: A Study of Monastic Culture*, trans. by Catherine Misrahi (New York: Fordham University Press, 1982), p. 96.

95 As cited in Dyer, 'The Psalms in Monastic Prayer', p. 69. Cf. 'Is not transcendental philosophy a fear of the sea? Something like a dike or sea-wall? A longing for the open ocean gnaws at us, as the land is gnawed by the sea. A dark fluidity at the roots of our nature rebels against the security of *terra firma*, provoking a wave of anxiety in which we are submerged, until we feel ourselves drowning, with representation draining away. *Nihil ulterius*.

ing concealed in the Scriptures, and though they resist easy classification, his methods, which, in keeping with the Neoplatonic tradition, maintained that not every scriptural expression (e.g. anthropomorphic terminology applied to the divinity) had a genuinely 'literal' sense (ergo Pseudo-Dionysius, who writes: '[the literal sense] could well mislead someone into thinking that the heavenly beings are golden or gleaming men, glamorous, wearing lustrous clothing, giving off flames which cause no harm or that they have other similar beauties with which the word of God has fashioned the heavenly minds. It was [precisely] to avoid this kind of misunderstanding among those incapable of rising above visible beauty that the pious theologians so wisely and upliftingly stooped to incongruous dissimilarities ['But I am a worm, and no man'. – Psalm 22:16] for by doing this they took account of our inherent tendency toward the material and our willingness to be lazily satisfied by base images. At the same time, they enabled that part of the soul which longs for the things above actually to rise up. Indeed the sheer crassness of the signs is a goad so that even the materially inclined cannot accept that it could be permitted or true that the celestial and divine sights could be conveyed by such shameful things. And remember too that there is nothing that lacks its own share of beauty, for as scripture rightly says, "Everything is good" [CH 141B-141C].⁹⁶ Cf. 'The worm stands for not standing for anything. It even knows how to bite off its own head, to swallow itself whole. "What should I do now?" And a voice said, "Eat! Eat Yourself!" He had no choice

Incipit Kant: We are not amphibians, but belong upon solid earth. Let us renounce all strange voyages. The age of desire is past. The new humanity I anticipate has no use for enigmatic horizons; it knows the ocean is madness and disease. Let me still your ancient tremors, and replace them with dreams of an iron shore. Reason in its legitimate function is a defence against the sea, which is also an inhibition of the terrestrial; retarding our tendency to waste painstakingly accumulated resources in futile expeditions, a "barrier opposed to the expenditure of forces [II 332]" as Bataille describes it. It is a fortified boundary, sealing out everything uncertain, irresolvable, dissolvant, a sea-wall against the unknown, against death' (Nick Land, *The Thirst for Annihilation: Georges Bataille and Virulent Nihilism* [London and New York: Routledge, 1992], p. 107).

96 Pseudo-Dionysius, *Celestial Hierarchy*, 141B-141C, in *The Complete Works*, p. 150.

but to eat, so He ate Himself! At that moment He found that He was Everything'),⁹⁷ embodied, and proposed therein, what were to become the definitive principles guiding biblical interpretation in the Middle Ages: the spiritual (also called 'allegorical') exegesis of the Alexandrian school.⁹⁸

One of the main straits by dint of which Alexandrian-Origenist principles penetrated Western scholasticism was through the writings of the aforementioned John Cassian, in the fifth century. Cassian had encountered Origen's teachings in Egypt, where he lived as a monk for fifteen years. Some time later, living in France, Cassian wrote the *Institutes* (*De institutionibus coenobiorum*) for the benefit of monks in his newly adopted land. This contained descriptions of the spiritual practices of Egyptian and Syrian monks, directions for communal prayer, and cures for the principle vices. For those on the monastic path to perfection his twenty-four *Conferences* (*Conlationes*) offered further guidance. In the *Conferences*, Cassian distinguished, as Origen had, between historical interpretation and spiritual insight, and he systematized the four 'senses' that were present in

97 Nicola Masciandaro, 'WormSign', *Melancology: Black Metal Theory and Ecology*, ed. by Scott Wilson (Winchester and Washington: Zero Books, 2014), pp. 81–101; p. 80. See Edia Connole and Scott Wilson, "[os mentis] mouth to mouth" with Nicola Masciandaro', in *Weaponising Speculation*, ed. by Caoimhe Doyle (New York: Punctum, 2014), pp. 43–60: 'Born of matter, and at the very bottom of the universe [cf. Aristotle's *Scala Naturae*, typified by de Boullée's depiction of an ascending linear order in nature in the *Physicorum elementorum* (1512)], "worm" is best suited to represent matter, but just as it can represent matter in its badness, it can also represent matter in its substantial goodness, thus serving as the living substantiation of the biblical statement, "everything is beautiful" (pp. 55–6). Cf. Saheb and Abaris, *Bergmetal*, p. 62: 'As a worm eats itself through earth, body is instrumental food and excremental casting of a more hidden movement: "You eat food, and to keep yourselves healthy and fit, you pass out the residue as excrement [...]. do you ever shed tears for the waste you eliminate? Do you ever think about it, or feel regret over it? Not at all [...]. if someone dear dies, why do you weep for that discarded body, which is like food to the soul? You preserve and protect your body to feed your soul. The body is the medium for the soul's progress. When your excrement is eliminated, you eat fresh food. Similarly with the disposal of the old body, you take a new body. So why worry and weep over that which is the law of nature and cannot be altered?" (MB)'.

98 See Dyer, 'The Psalms in Monastic Prayer', p. 69.

essence in Origen's writings: the literal (or historical), the allegorical, the moral (or tropological), and the anagogical. In quoting Galatians 4:22ff, he provided an example of how Scripture could be interpreted in these four different ways, with his test-case of the word 'Jerusalem'. This test-case, which was profoundly influential in the Middle Ages and, indeed, beyond – as late as Luther and Melancthon – was cogently paraphrased by Guibert of Nogent, who wrote a short treatise in the eleventh century on the way a sermon ought to be composed. There are four ways of interpreting Scripture, he says here,

The first is history, which speaks of actual events as they occurred; the second is allegory, in which one thing stands for something else; the third is tropology, or moral instruction, which treats of the ordering or arranging of one's life; and the last is [anagogy] or spiritual enlightenment, through which we who are about to treat of lofty and heavenly topics are led to a higher way of life. For example, the word Jerusalem: historically, it represents a specific city; in allegory it represents holy Church; tropologically or morally, it is the soul of every faithful man who longs for the vision of eternal peace; and anagogically it refers to the life of the heavenly citizens, who already see the God of Gods, revealed in all His glory in Sion.⁹⁹

Cassian maintained that, after the suppression of unreasonable desires and the cultivation of virtue or 'practical knowledge', there is a 'theoretical knowledge' that terminates in the most profound understanding of divine and sacred truths.¹⁰⁰ Here, he does not mean 'theoretical' in the modern sense of the word, but in the sense of an eminently 'contemplative' knowledge that persisted in medieval times, and that had passed from ancient Greek philosophy and

99 As cited in Minnis, *Medieval Theory of Authorship*, p. 34; *Patrologia latina*, clvi, 25D–26A, in *Readings in Medieval Rhetoric*, ed. by J. M. Miller, M. H. Prosser and T. W. Benson (Bloomington and London, 1973), pp. 170–1. Cf. John Cassian, *Conferences*, xiv.8, trans. by Colm Luibhead (New York: Paulist Press, 1985), p. 160: 'And if we wish it, these four modes of representation flow into a unity so that the one Jerusalem can be understood in four different ways: in the historical sense of the city of the Jews, in allegory as the church of Christ, in anagoge as the heavenly city of God "which is mother to us all" (Gal 4.26), in the tropological sense as the human soul which under this name, is frequently criticized or blamed by the Lord'.

100 Cassian, *Conferences*, xiv. 2, pp. 155–73; p. 157–8.

Neoplatonism, with a modified meaning adapted to the Christian (Triune) system, into the terminology of Christian mysticism. The Triune God, to quote Paul, is the being in which 'we live and move and have our being' (Acts 17:28). From a Triune perspective, then, all knowledge of God is necessarily assimilative. To put it in Thomist terms: 'all [knowledge of God] is produced by an assimilation of the knower to the thing known, so that assimilation is said to be the cause of knowledge'.¹⁰¹ Importantly, in the Scriptures, knowledge of God does not allow for a separation between knowing and doing. In following Scripture, medieval exegetes did not distinguish between theory and practice as the Greeks did (hence how the meaning of *theoria* is modified and adapted). Rather, those who live in sin are said to have no knowledge of God (Hos 4:1; 1 Cor 1:21; Gal 4:8; 1 Thess 1:8), while those who live virtuously are said simply to know God (Hos 6:6; Rom 11:3; Gal 4:9). From this perspective, knowledge of God is not a precondition for salvation, as theory is sometimes said to be a prerequisite to practice. Instead, knowledge of God is coeval with our salvation.¹⁰² All goes back to Paul's words in Galatians: 'I live, yet not I, but Christ liveth in me' (Gal 2: 20). Varieties of this claim can be found throughout the mystical tradition, wherein theoretical (or 'contemplative') knowledge is understood to be knowledge acquired through love, *per amorem agnoscimus* (Gregory, *Moralia* 31:101),¹⁰³ 'You know, I say, not through faith, but through love,' '[w]hen we love supracelestial realities, we begin to know what we already love, since love itself is knowledge' (Gregory, *In Evangelia* 14.4, 27.4),¹⁰⁴ 'Being united in love in this way [...] the soul becomes, as it were, changed into God,' 'the spirit dies and yet it is alive in the marvels of the Godhead' (Catherine of Sienna, *The Dialogue*),¹⁰⁵ 'I and God are one,' 'I am an unmoved cause that

101 Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I, q. 12, a.9. <<http://www.sacred-texts.com/chr/aquinas/summa/>> (accessed 21/10/14).

102 Cf. Saheb and Abaris, *Bergmetal*, p. 60: "The process of perception runs parallel to the process of creation, and the reversing of the process of perception without obliterating consciousness amounts to realizing the nothingness of the universe as a separate entity" (MB, *Discourses*) – and the reversal of time itself: "If the soul withdrew, [...] again into its primal unity" (Plotinus, *Enneads*).

103 Gregory, *Moralia*, 31:101, as cited in Leclercq, *The Love of Learning*, p. 33.

104 Gregory, *In Evangelia*, 14.4, 27.4, cited in *ibid.*, p. 33–4.

105 Catherine of Sienna, *Little Talks with God (The Dialogue of Catherine of Si-*

moves all things' (Meister Eckhart, Sermon 52),¹⁰⁶ 'restored to [...] the primal fact that her existence and mine are coeval, that we go way back' (Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis').¹⁰⁷ (Or, as Masciandaro would say, differently, in opining the love of Black metal as the love of that which materially makes, and perceptually does, what mysticism spiritually is: 'All love is a fire, but a spiritual fire. What a corporeal fire does for [metal], this fire [...] does for an impure cold and hardened heart [...] and the mind changes into the similitude of Him who inflames it. The whole mind becomes white hot, flares up, and liquefies in the love of God').¹⁰⁸



Sleep, *Jerusalem* (from the unauthorized *Rise Above* release [1999] designed by Doug Ebright of Visual Flight).

Hence, when Peter the Venerable writes of the then Prior of Cluny, Mathew of Albano, '*Non relinquebat partem aliquam theoriae intactum*', it should not be translated, as Leclercq notes has been done, '[t]here was not a single point of theory that he neglected'.¹⁰⁹ For at issue in this sentence is not a theory of monastic life, but rather the very nature of theory itself, which, understood in its fullest sense,

enna), trans. by Henry L. Carrigan Jr. (Brewster, Massachusetts: Paraclete Press, 2010), p. 3.

¹⁰⁶ Meister Eckhart, Sermon 52, in *The Essential Writings of Christian Mysticism*, ed. Bernard McGinn (New York: Modern Library, 2006), p. 443.

¹⁰⁷ Masciandaro, 'Anti-Cosmosis', p. 80.

¹⁰⁸ Masciandaro, 'Mystical Love of Black Metal'.

¹⁰⁹ As cited in Leclercq, *The Love of Learning*, p. 99.

as 'divine contemplation' (*theorica contemplatio*), cannot be comprehended in terms of an extrinsic reality, since God is not an object to be known extrinsically. De Lubac captures this perfectly when he describes our knowledge of God as an inter-Trinitarian reality wherein the beatific vision (understood as the *telos* of all knowledge of God) is not conceived as 'the contemplation of a spectacle, but an intimate participation in the vision the Son has of the Father in the bosom of the Trinity'.¹¹⁰ Cassian was instrumental in the transmission of this conception and its expression to the West, where the word *theoria* is often accompanied by adjectives which prove that it is understood as a participation and an assimilation, a knowledge arising not through domination, but through attentiveness to the object in contemplation; as Murray Rae notes in 'Incline Your Ears So That You May Live', '[s]uch attentiveness conforms the knower to what is known rather than the other way around'.¹¹¹ This gives rise to terms like *theoricus* and *theoreticus* in expressions like *theorica mysteria*, and *theorica studia*, 'which [like *theorica metallum nigri*] must not be understood in the modern sense of the word, as "[Black metal] theoretical studies," but in the medieval sense of *theoria* as amorous affinity [quite literally, then, as "love of Black metal"]'.¹¹²

Masciandaro, for example, is combining all of these ideas when he says:

I love black metal. In secret. In the secrecy wherein black metal keeps its own secret, above all from itself, and below. 'Love sets on fire the one who finds it. At the same time it seals his lips so that no smoke comes out. Love is meant to be experienced and not disclosed [MB] [...] So it is true what The Scapegoat said, that 'the first

¹¹⁰ Henri de Lubac, *The Mystery of the Supernatural* (New York: Crossroads Publishing, 1998), p. 228. Cf. Saheb and Abaris, *Bergmetal*, p. 61: 'Lights and sight are for those who do not see the EYE [...] "The eye with which I see God is the same eye with which God sees me" (Meister Eckhart, *Complete Mystical Works*, Sermon 57)'; Pseudo-Dionysius, *Divine Names*, 708D, in *The Complete Works*, p. 80: 'And the same happens with our intelligent powers which, when the soul becomes divinized, concentrate sightlessly and through an unknowing union on the rays of "unapproachable light"'.

¹¹¹ Murray Rae, 'Incline Your Ear So That You May Live': Principles of Biblical Epistemology', in *The Bible and Epistemology; Biblical Soundings on the Knowledge of God* (Milton Keynes, U.K.: Paternoster, 2007), p. 161.

¹¹² Leclercq, *The Love of Learning*, p. 100.

rule of black metal is that YOU DO NOT FUCKING TALK ABOUT BLACK METAL.' About, from OE *onbutan*, means 'on the outside of, around.' No one speaks about black metal – they do not know what they are talking about, nor what they are doing [forgive them]. Discourse on black metal is blasphemy, heresy, sacrilege [...] Do not talk about it. We will speak *in* black metal, there, where the secret of black metal is, wherever black metal is the secret of itself. Into the Infernal Regions of the Ancient Cult. Because black metal is love.¹¹³

¹¹³ Masciandaro, 'Mystical Love of Black Metal'. Cf. Masciandaro's commentary on Shakespeare's 'Of Plications', regarding the line, '*which only I have seen and will keep forever a secret: "Seul le secret voit dans le secret, comme Noir en Noir"*' (François Laruelle, *Du noir univers*) [Only the secret sees into the secret, like Black in Black]. Nor does one see the color black without seeing black itself. Black is the universal essential mirage. In a universe where the geologic and elemental domain recedes and melts into spectra, like the meteorite in Lovecraft's *The Color Out of Space*, black is the visible secret place where the primordially novel – something "from unformed realms of infinity beyond all Nature as we know it" – emerges, something whose obscurity is at once the veil of an unknown clarity – "this new glow was something definite and distinct, and appeared to shoot up from the black pit like a softened ray from a searchlight" – and the bewildering vista of even deeper black, the unimaginably intimate vision of something "whose mere existence stuns the brain and numbs us with the black extra-cosmic gulfs it throws open before our frenzied eyes" (Lovecraft, *At the Mountains of Madness*). Or, in the words of Isaiah, "*Secretum meum mihi, secretum meum mihi, vae mihi*" (Isaiah 24:16) [My secret to myself, my secret to myself, woe is me]' (p. 33).